

## A

**By, on or in + noun**

I took his pen **by mistake** [I thought it was my pen].

These shoes are made **by hand** [not using a machine].

I met them **by chance** [it wasn't planned; it was luck].



He broke the plate **by accident** [he did not want or plan to do it].



He broke the plate **on purpose** [he wanted to do it; it was his intention].

My boss is **on the phone** at the moment. [using the phone]

The workers are **on strike** [they refuse to work because of a problem over pay, hours, etc.].

The books were **on display** in the window. [in the window for people to look at]

Part of the building was **on fire** [burning].

Most of the passengers are now **on board** [on the train, boat, plane, etc.].

Why are they always **in a hurry** [needing to do something or go somewhere very quickly]?

I explained everything **in detail** [including all the important information].

She won't make that mistake again **in future**.

The poor little girl was **in tears** [crying].

## B

**Phrases easily confused**

Sometimes two prepositions can be used with the same noun, but the meaning is different.

Lessons begin at 8.30 and the students are usually here **on time** [at 8.30].

If we hurry, we'll be there **in time** [before the time we need to be there].

We were tired of waiting, so **in the end** we went home. [finally, after a lot of time or thought]

**At the end** of the book they get married. [in the last part]

To be successful **in business** it's important to get on well with people. [working as businesspeople]

They're both in Germany **on business** [they are there for work, not a holiday].

I'm afraid this book's a bit **out-of-date** [old and not useful, or not correct in its information].

I try to keep **up-to-date** with all the changes. [knowing all the most recent ideas and information]

I'll see you **in a moment** [not now, but very soon; *syn* **in a minute**].

I can't speak to you **at the moment** [now; *syn* **right now**].

**Common mistakes**

I'm busy **at the moment**. (NOT I'm busy ~~in this~~ moment.)